PSYCHOLOGICAL/COGNITIVE FALSE BELIEF #67 · ABUSE

# “Kindness is a trap. If someone is gentle with me, they are getting ready to hurt me.”

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## Where it often comes from

If gentleness was once the doorway to harm, kindness itself starts to feel like bait. A soft voice, a favor, or patience can make your body brace. That reaction is understandable. The lie says every gentle person is getting ready to hurt you, so you must refuse care. Some people are unsafe, and you are allowed to be careful. Not every kind person is the person who hurt you. A counselor can help you tell the difference without shaming the alarm. If you are not safe right now, call 911. You can also call the National Domestic Violence Hotline at 1-800-799-7233. If a child is being hurt, call Childhelp at 1-800-422-4453. A counselor can help you at a pace that is safe. You do not have to do this alone, or all at once.

## What Scripture teaches

You can cast anxiety on God because He cares for you. His care is not a lure. He is near the brokenhearted. Jesus gives peace and says not to be afraid. Nothing can separate you from the love of God. Believers are told to carry burdens, which is a form of kindness. Scripture does not tell you to trust every smile. It does tell you that real care exists, and that God’s kindness is not the opening move of harm.

> *“Cast all your anxiety on Him, because He cares for you”* (1 Peter 5:7).

## Also see

> “The LORD is near to the brokenhearted; He saves the contrite in spirit” (Psalm 34:18).

> “Peace I leave with you; My peace I give to you. I do not give to you as the world gives. Do not let your hearts be troubled; do not be afraid” (John 14:27).

> “For I am convinced that neither death nor life, neither angels nor principalities, neither the present nor the future, nor any powers, neither height nor depth, nor anything else in all creation, will be able to separate us from the love of God that is in Christ Jesus our Lord” (Romans 8:38–39).

> “Carry one another’s burdens, and in this way you will fulfill the law of Christ” (Galatians 6:2).

## Common self-statements

- If they are nice, they want something.
- Gentleness is how it starts.
- I should reject help before it turns.
- No one is kind unless they are planning harm.
- I would rather be harsh than fooled.
- Even God’s kindness is a trick.

## Common logical errors

- Overgeneralization: Turning one betrayal of kindness into “all kindness is a trap.”
- Fortune telling: Deciding a gentle moment will certainly become harm.
- Mind reading: Assigning a hidden motive to every kind act.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling braced and calling the brace proof of danger.

## Challenging questions

- Who used kindness badly, and who has not?
- What would slow trust look like, short of refusing everyone?
- Is this the same person, or a reminder in my body?
- What kindness have I received that did not turn into harm?
- How is God's care different from the care that was misused?
- What limit can I set while I am still receiving help?

## Truth summary

> Some kindness was misused, and that does not make all kindness a trap. I can go slowly, and I can receive care from safe people and from God.

## Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Trust
- Fear
- Love, By God
- Friendship
- Help

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Love
- Anxiety/Worry/Fear
- Thinking, Healthy

## What does a mentally healthy Christian look like?



Cover of Christlike: Walking the Walk, The Mentally Healthy Christian, by Dr. Brian Campbell with Rev. Jim Angelakos

From *Christlike: Walking the Walk* by Dr. Brian Campbell. A portrait, verse by verse, of how a mentally healthy Christian thinks, feels, and lives.

Read excerpts from "The Mentally Healthy Christian" (with every Scripture written out)

## Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

## Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

## Songs that speak truth to this belief

**He Knows** — Jeremy Camp
Jesus knows harm and still offers kindness that is not a setup.

**Love Take Me Over** — Steven Curtis Chapman
Receiving love can be slow. It does not have to be a trap.

**Jesus** — Chris Tomlin
Jesus' gentleness is not the start of harm.

**Turn Your Eyes Upon Jesus** — Reawaken Hymns
Look at Christ's kindness when a gentle person feels dangerous.

*Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, what is one step I could take today?"*

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

# My Plan for Replacing "Kindness is a trap. If someone is gentle with me, they are getting ready to hurt me."

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

## 1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

*Rate it now so you can see your progress later.*

"Kindness is a trap. If someone is gentle with me, they are getting ready to hurt me." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

## 2 My best question

*The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.*

- ☐ Who used kindness badly, and who has not?
- ☐ What would slow trust look like, short of refusing everyone?
- ☐ Is this the same person, or a reminder in my body?
- ☐ What kindness have I received that did not turn into harm?
- ☐ How is God's care different from the care that was misused?
- ☐ What limit can I set while I am still receiving help?

My own question: _____

## 3 My replacement truth

*The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.*

- ☐ Some kindness was misused, and that does not make all kindness a trap. I can go slowly, and I can receive care from safe people and from God.
- ☐ My alarm can be honored without becoming a law about everyone.
- ☐ God's care is not a setup.
- ☐ I can go slowly with a gentle person.
- ☐ I am allowed to receive help.
- ☐ One unsafe person does not equal every kind person.

In my own words: _____

## 4 My Scripture

*The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.*

- ☐ 1 Peter 5:7
  *"Cast all your anxiety on Him, because He cares for you."*
- ☐ Psalm 34:18
  *"The LORD is near to the brokenhearted; He saves the contrite in spirit."*
- ☐ John 14:27
  *"Peace I leave with you; My peace I give to you. I do not give to you as the world gives. Do not let your hearts be troubled; do not be afraid."*

A verse I found myself:

# Practicing the Truth

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## 5 My practice plan

*Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.*

### EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

### PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] When kindness felt like a setup: Each day, write down one moment when gentleness made you brace for harm. Write what happened, what you told yourself, and one more accurate statement.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  *For example, 1 Peter 5:7 becomes: "Sarah can write: "I can bring this fear to God, because His care is not a trap.""*
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Trust" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio or the Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

## 6 My action step this week

*Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.*

*Choose steps you can do safely. If this belief comes with hopelessness or thoughts of ending your life, call or text 988 (the Suicide & Crisis Lifeline), or call 911 in an emergency. You do not have to carry this alone. If you are not safe right now, call 911 or 1-800-799-7233.*

- [ ] Name the old pattern and the present person. Two lines, no story: who misused kindness, and who is in front of you now.
- [ ] Receive one small help from someone you and your counselor consider safe. Write what they did afterward.
- [ ] Keep a limit. You can accept kindness and still say no to more than you want.
- [ ] Pray 1 Peter 5:7 when a gentle voice makes you brace.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

## 7 End-of-week check-in

*Bring this page to your next session.*

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie “Kindness is a trap. If someone is gentle with me, they are getting ready to hurt me.”: _____ %

My truth: _____ %

## Daily practice tracker

| Day | Read my card | Said my verse | Used my reminder | A kindness that did not turn into harm |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Mon | | | | |
| Tue | | | | |
| Wed | | | | |
| Thu | | | | |
| Fri | | | | |
| Sat | | | | |
| Sun | | | | |

## My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

| Day | Song I listened to | What it told me that challenges the lie |
|---|---|---|
| Mon | | |
| Tue | | |
| Wed | | |
| Thu | | |
| Fri | | |
| Sat | | |
| Sun | | |

## My Truth Card

**THE LIE**

~~Kindness is a trap. If someone is gentle with me, they are getting ready to hurt me~~

**THE TRUTH**

**GOD'S WORD**

*Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.*

## Prayer

*Lord, kindness makes me brace. Some of that wisdom was earned. Teach me that not every gentle person is a trap, and that Your care is safe. Help me go slowly. Amen.*

*Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.*